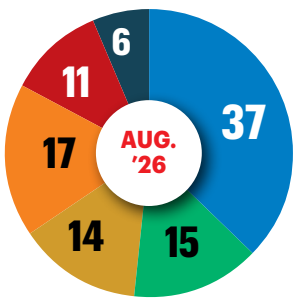


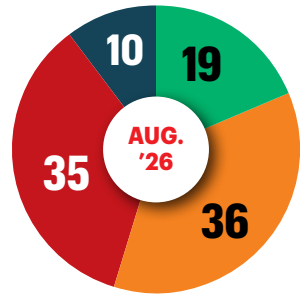
WORLD'S A STAGE Prime Minister Narendra Modi with other global leaders at the G7 Summit in Evian-les-Bains, France; June 16

Q. How would you rate the Modi government's overall handling of foreign policy?



More than half of respondents give a thumbs up to foreign policy under the NDA government

Q. Which of the following best describes your view of India's relationship with the United States?



Almost equal numbers hold exactly opposite views about how India manages US pressure

Q. What should be India's main approach towards China?



Opinion is split between dialogue, economic caution and military deterrence

All figures in % and rounded off; DK/ CS: Don't know/ can't say

In an increasingly fragmented global economic and security order marked by a stop-start conflict in the Middle East, the continuing Russia-Ukraine war and an unpredictable Trump administration in the US, India's foreign policy has been all about creating room for manoeuvre. New Delhi is pursuing strategic autonomy through multi-alignment—deepening partnerships with the US and western powers while preserving its defence and energy ties with Russia, managing a complex relationship with China and strengthening its voice in the Global South.

As external affairs minister S. Jaishankar put it recently, the world is increasingly defined by "competition, conflict and the growing use of economic and strategic leverage". It is a reality that has shaped India's pragmatic approach of avoiding camps while protecting its national interests. This met with approval in INDIA TODAY's Mood of the Nation (MOTN) survey— 52 per cent (37 per cent 'very good' and 15 per cent 'good') express appreciation of the Modi government's handling of foreign policy. However, 28 per cent rate it negatively.

India-US ties during the Donald Trump 2.0 administration have had their ups and downs. US tariffs on Indian products and Trump's praise of Pakistan's military leadership have tested the 'strategic partnership'. India-US ties are shaped by mutual interests and tangible outcomes. Washington's invitation to ISRO (Indian Space Research Organisation) to join its Moon Base programme signals deeper space cooperation, while India's Rs 1,943-crore, 30-month lease of two MQ-9B Sea-Guardian drones highlights the partnership's security dimension. On what best describes India-US ties, 36 per cent of respondents feel that India has succeeded in protecting its interests despite US pressure, while 35 per cent state the opposite, saying that India often gave in to such coercive tactics.

On August 25, national security advisor Ajit Doval attended the 25th round of Special Representative-level